



ASUS P525 Full PDA, Half Phone

ASUS has brought their full line-up of PDA phones to India, and the P525 is a PDA with a number pad—something of a rarity. It's a touchscreen running Windows Mobile 5 and the charcoal grey that made the P535 such a good looker makes another appearance. The P525 is a beautiful beast—all smoky grey with chrome buttons down the side panel in sharp contrast. We also liked the screen—crisp, clear and good contrast, visible even in daylight.

The number keys look like sculpted buttons that have been integrated into the body—they give just the right amount of feedback when used, and never feel tacky. We don't like the joystick, though—it's too small and smooth and there's insufficient tactile feedback. We also didn't like

the fact that the joystick's in between the number keys 2 and 5—this affects access to the number 2.

Voice Commander makes another appearance—a really excellent piece of code, this—that allows you to do so much more with voice commands. The excellent business card scanner is also preinstalled. There's also a password protected security application called My Secrets that allows you to protect your files by encrypting them. All the usual Windows Mobile applications are present as well.

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Bundle	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

There's a dedicated button for the camera, which is surprisingly good for a PDA. The volume button is very ergonomic, as is the *hold* button—which prevents keypad, button and screen use.

While the loudspeaker offers decent volume, we lament the volume levels on the hands-free kit—it's just too low, be it music or a voice call. While on the topic of calls, signal quality could have been better—a patent weakness of most PDAs. If you need a good phone, please look elsewhere.

Where the P525 scores is in PDA functionality (even though it foregoes a QWERTY keypad), looks—nobody will disagree here—and, of course, the software package that improves productivity by quite an extent. At Rs 19,000 the ASUS P525 is a good PDA, but a strictly average phone. It's flashy for sure, and will draw glances anywhere. You'll have to decide what is



more important to you—PDA features, or a phone.

Specifications

Weight—160 grams, Screen—2.8-inches, 240x320 pixels, 65K colours, 128 MB inbuilt memory, 2 MP camera with autofocus

Contact: ASUS Technology Pvt. Ltd
Phone: 022-6766 8800
Web site: <http://in.asus.com>
Price: Rs 19,000

BenQ-Siemens Q-fi EF71 A Stylish Multimedia Clamshell

Supporting a stylish brushed aluminium exterior, the BenQ-Siemens Q-fi EF71 looks elegant and has a pleasant feel. The hinge of this ruggedly-built phone allows little play and feels very strong. When opened, it's all jet black; only the 4-way rocker and the border of the keypad sport a metallic finish.

The blue backlit keys are well-spaced and extremely comfortable when SMSing. The icon-based UI is easy to use and the colour LCD is good, as is the external white OLED display used for various status messages.

The Q-fi range is music-focused, and this is one of the first phones in this series. Media playback keys are present on the lid, and

there is also a music button at the side to start the media player. The 10-band equaliser makes listening to music a pleasurable experience. The 2.0 MP camera does not feature auto-focus, but still does a good job. You can't zoom while taking still photos at the highest supported resolution.

The phone has a paltry internal memory of just 24 MB, so adding a microSD card becomes compulsory. The memory is not hot-swappable—you need to open

RATINGS	
Feature	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Ease of Use	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆



the phone and remove the battery to access the slot. PC connection has three modes: mass storage device, Modem / PC Sync, or Webcam.

Voice quality is satisfactory, and the speaker is loud enough. There is a

special Q-fi mode that disables the mobile network connection and lets you access only multimedia features along with FM and Bluetooth. The FM Transmitter lets you wirelessly transmit your calls or music to an FM receiver up to two meters away. There's also an Answering Machine feature. The price, though, is a little on the higher side at Rs 12,955.

Specifications

GSM900/1800/1900; Display: Internal: 2.2-inch TFT 176x220 pixels 262K colours, External: OLED 128x64 pixels; Camera: 2.0 MP, 9x digital zoom; Weight: 100 gm; Dimensions: 47(W) x 18.5(D) x 90(H) mm.

Contact: BenQ India Pvt Ltd
Phone: 1800-22-0808
E-mail: benq.mobile@benq.com
Web site: www.benq.co.in
Price: Rs 12,955

Computer Kitchen MP4 Watch 1 GB Bonsai From The Orient

This watch is solidly constructed and encased in a rugged steel case, with very firm rubber straps. It's just as comfortable to wear as any other watch, but due to its rather large size, you better have large wrists to carry it around in style.

This ultra small PMP (Personal Media Player) boasts of a capacity of 1 GB, which is not much, especially if you want to watch movies and videos. There are 2 and 4 GB versions that are better options in such cases. It shows up as a removable drive in XP and you can easily copy files to it using Windows Explorer.

Learning to use the controls takes awhile. The

buttons are hard—it would have been better if they would have come with some kind of soft padding that would have increased their surface area and added to comfort. Navigation is not intuitive, but once you get used to it, you can find your way around.

The display quality of the 1.5 inch colour OLED is nothing to brag about. You can't just play MP4 files directly, and need to convert them using the

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Ease of use	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

provided software first—even then, playback stutters—it drops a video frame every now and then.

MP3 playback is quite decent, and the bundled earphones do a rather good job. There are preset equalisers to adjust music to suit your taste. There is an FM Radio, a photo viewer, voice recorder, small games and even an e-book reader.

The battery lasts for around 6 and half hours of MP3 playback, which is a little less than an average MP3 player. When you watch video, the battery lasts for just under 2 hours—you should therefore not hope to watch movies, but watching music videos is a better usage option. Yes, it also has a watch (analog-cum-digital). It costs Rs 5,990—too high for what's on offer.



Specifications

Capacity: 1 GB; Display: 1.5-inch 262K colour OLED; Audio: MP3, WMA; Video: NXV (converted using bundled software); FM Radio; Dimensions: 39 (W) x 12 (D) x 39 (H) mm; Weight: 66 gm

Contact: Compute Kitchen
Phone: 080-41131001
E-mail: info@computerkitchen.com
Web site: www.computerkitchen.com
Price: Rs 5,990

Cowon iAudio 7 4 GB Miniscule Music Monster

Cowon's always been preferred by music lovers on the go for one reason—sound quality. Their PMPs have always been regarded as works of art, and the iAudio 7 is true to the heritage. A piano black (smudge magnet!) finish, four beautifully backlit buttons on the front bezel and a host of attractive matte-chromed buttons on the right side add to the looks and retain total functionality. The tiny iAudio 7 feels solid in hand—build quality is exemplary.

A 1.3 inch, 18-bit colour (262 K) screen allows for 7 lines of text and looks crisp, but a video player this is not—in our opinion a video player needs to have a much larger screen. There are numerous little features—direct line-in recording from multiple sources like CD players, TVs etc, a clock with alarm and support for scheduled

recordings, FM radio and lyrics display support.

The music quality is—in a word—terrific! With great clarity and deep bass that sounds tight, mids and highs are also very prominent. Most PMPs have a tendency to highlight bass and mute trebles—not here. The iAudio 7 brings out the best of instrumentals and we thoroughly enjoyed out sessions with Vanessa Mae and Kenny G—in fact the iAudio 7 is very suitable to classical stuff—all Bhimsen Joshi aficionados take note. Vocals are well defined too—we tried a variety of artists from The Doors to Alan Jackson and Charlotte

RATINGS	
Feature	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Build Quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆



Church. No complaints, except you'd better get yourself a good set of earbuds—like Creative's EP630 or Bose's Intra Ears—maybe even a noise cancelling set. The default earplugs are better than most regular stuff—and easily kill the iPod's bundled earplugs—but the mid-range seems a touch recessed. Of course how much you want to spend on cans depends on how serious you are about your music. This tiny player drives most headphones—except for audiophile grade headphones which are real high-impedance stuff.

To be honest, we'd reckon Cowon's own D2 and Apple's iPod Video and Nano would just squeak ahead on sheer music quality—but the difference isn't much.

At Rs 10,000, the iAudio 7 is costly—especially since the new iPod Nanos are significantly cheaper.

Specifications

Output rating 52 mW (26x2), 3.5 mm jacks (in and out),

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Phone: 022-28743457
Web site: iaudio@lipap.com
Price: Rs 10,000